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Project P8

Enhancing Web Accessibility Standards

*Implementation of User-Centric Customization Interfaces and
CSS-based Contrast Optimization*

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1. Abstract

2. Acknowledgement

3. Introduction

The previous project, *Accessibility on the Web – Where we Stand* [1], examined the fundamental principles of digital inclusion in modern web applications. It explored how semantic HTML forms the foundation of accessibility, provided an overview of both common and lesser-known native elements, and clarified the roles of ARIA and WCAG. In addition, it introduced the basics of accessibility debugging, testing, and the practical use of screen readers.

Building on that foundation, this project focuses on essential aspects of accessibility that may appear less technical in the traditional sense, but are equally important for creating an inclusive digital world. While the previous project concentrated primarily on the structural and technical mechanisms behind the scenes, it did not examine the visual design of web applications. These design decisions are far more than aesthetic choices. They play a decisive role in determining whether a web application becomes a welcoming space or a digital dead end for many users.

3.1. Objective of this Project

This project aims to explore accessibility in greater depth by examining ways to build on and extend existing browser standards. It also investigates additional techniques and approaches that can simplify the user journeys of people with impairments, making web applications more user-friendly and adaptable to individual needs.

4. Theory

The following chapter introduces CSS and JavaScript features, along with patterns and standards that can serve as a foundation for improving visual accessibility. These techniques help create a better user experience, particularly for people with visual impairments.

4.1. CSS Media Queries

CSS Media Queries allow developers to apply different styles based on the characteristics of the device or environment used to display a web page. This mechanism is commonly used to create responsive layouts that adapt their appearance according to the available screen width.

Listing 1 below illustrates the syntax of a media query as defined by the W3C.

```
@media <media-query-list> {  
  <rule-list>  
}
```

Listing 1: Syntax of a media query, where `<media-query-list>` contains `<media-type>` values, `<media-feature>` values, and logical operators.

In web development, the `screen` media type is the most commonly used, but media queries can also target printers by using `print`. If no media type is specified, the default value is `all`, which applies the styles to all devices.

Media features are where media queries become particularly powerful, as more than 40 features are currently available. They allow styles to respond to specific characteristics of the user's environment. Common examples include `max-width` and `max-height`, as well as their counterparts `min-width` and `min-height`. These features are widely used to create responsive websites with layouts optimized for different screen sizes.

Listing 2 demonstrates a media query that uses the `screen` media type together with the `max-width` media feature.

Some media features take accessibility needs and user preferences into account. They make it possible to adapt the presentation of a website to individual requirements. Despite their importance, they are still used less frequently than they should be. The following media features are particularly relevant when building web applications that aim to be accessible to all users. [2]

```
@media screen and (max-width: 768px) {  
  body {  
    background-color: lightskyblue;  
  }  
}
```

Listing 2: Example of a media query that changes the background color on smaller screens using the `screen` media type and the `max-width` media feature.

4.1.1. Reduced Motion

The `prefers-reduced-motion` media feature indicates whether a user has enabled a system setting that reduces non-essential motion. If the value is set to `reduce`, animations and transitions should be limited to the bare minimum.

A value of `no-preference` indicates that the user has not expressed a preference for reduced motion, allowing animations and transitions to be displayed without restriction. [3]

4.1.2. Contrast

The `prefers-contrast` media feature allows users to indicate whether they prefer content to be presented with higher or lower contrast. A value of `no-preference` indicates that the user has not configured a contrast preference.

If the value is set to `more`, the user requests a higher level of contrast. Conversely, a value of `less` indicates that a lower contrast is preferred.

The value `custom` indicates that the user prefers a specific set of colors. This color palette is typically defined through the `forced-colors` media feature, which is explained in the following section. [4]

4.1.3. Forced Colors

The `forced-colors` media feature detects whether the user agent has enabled a forced color mode, such as Windows High Contrast. This media feature has the value `active` when such a mode is enabled and `none` when it is not.

When forced colors mode is active, many color values defined in the style sheet are overridden by the browser during the painting process. The exact colors applied depend on the semantic role of each element. In addition, browsers may draw backplates behind text to preserve legibility and maintain sufficient contrast when text appears on top of images or patterned backgrounds.

Developers are generally not encouraged to create a separate design specifically for users who enable forced colors mode. Instead, this media query should be used to make targeted adjustments when certain components do not work well in this context. For example, a button that relies solely on `box-shadow` to stand out from

the background may lose its visual distinction. In such cases, replacing the shadow with a visible border can provide a more robust solution. [5]

4.1.4. Reduced Transparency

The `prefers-reduced-transparency` media feature indicates whether a user has enabled a system setting to reduce transparent or translucent visual effects. If the value is set to `reduce`, transparency effects such as blurred overlays or frosted glass backgrounds should be minimized or removed. A value of `no-preference` indicates that the user has not expressed a preference and that the default design can be used.

Reducing transparency can improve contrast and readability, particularly for users who find translucent interface elements distracting or difficult to perceive.

Support for this media feature is currently limited and it is not yet fully supported by Firefox and Safari. [6]

4.1.5. Color Scheme

A more widely adopted media feature is `prefers-color-scheme`. It indicates whether the user prefers a light or dark color theme configured through the operating system or the user agent. The value `light` represents a light color theme, while `dark` represents a dark color theme. [7]

4.1.6. Inverted Colors

The `inverted-colors` media feature detects whether the user agent is displaying content with inverted colors. Color inversion can introduce visual side effects, such as shadows appearing as highlights, which may reduce the readability of the content. By responding to this media feature, developers can make targeted adjustments to preserve the visual integrity of the page.

Support for this media feature is currently limited and, at the time of writing, it is only supported by Safari. [8]

4.1.7. Accessing Media Features through JavaScript

The `window` interface provides the `matchMedia()` method, which returns a `MediaQueryList` object. This object can be used to determine whether the current `document` matches a given media query string. Listing 3 demonstrates this approach using the `prefers-color-scheme` media feature.

```
const isDarkTheme = window.matchMedia("(prefers-color-scheme:
dark)").matches;
```

Listing 3: Checking whether the user's system settings prefer a dark color scheme.

This allows developers to respond to user preferences not only in CSS, but also within JavaScript logic and application-specific features. [9]

4.1.8. Changes in the World of Media Queries

CSS media queries continue to evolve, but one important aspect of visual accessibility is still not addressed. Different forms of color blindness and other impairments that affect color perception are not yet covered by an official media feature.

An open issue in the W3C’s `csswg-drafts` repository proposes a new media feature called `color-vision-adjustment`. Its goal is to improve web accessibility by allowing developers to respond directly to the needs of users with color vision deficiencies.

The proposal includes support for several specific conditions, including `protanopia` (red deficiency), `deuteranopia` (red-green deficiency), `tritanopia` (blue-yellow deficiency), and `achromatopsia` (near-total color blindness, resulting in grayscale vision). These impairments were introduced in the previous P7 project through bookmarklets that simulated their visual effects.

A media feature of this kind would increase awareness of color vision deficiencies and provide developers with a standardized way to adapt interfaces to the needs of affected users. [10]

4.1.9. Deprecated Features

Earlier versions of CSS included media types such as `embossed`, `aural`, and `braille`, which were intended to address specific accessibility needs. These media types were later deprecated because the distinction between device categories was expected to become less meaningful over time. In addition, media types describe classes of devices rather than the actual capabilities they support. [11], [12]

4.1.10. Security Concerns

Information exposed through media queries can be used to build a browser fingerprint, which may allow a device to be identified and tracked across websites. To reduce this risk, browsers may deliberately modify or generalize certain reported values.

Some browsers also provide settings that further limit this information. For example, Firefox offers the “Resist Fingerprinting” option, which causes many media queries to return standardized values instead of device-specific settings. [12]

4.2. CSS Custom Properties

CSS custom properties, also known as CSS variables, are named values that can be reused throughout a style sheet. Their value depends on the scope in which they are defined, but within that scope they evaluate to the same value wherever they are used. This makes styles easier to maintain and reduces duplication.

Custom properties are defined using a name that begins with two dashes, `--`, followed by a descriptive identifier. Their value can be accessed using the CSS `var()` function. Listing 4 demonstrates how the custom property `--primary-color` can be defined once and reused throughout a website. This approach is particularly useful when implementing multiple themes, such as light and dark mode, because colors can be changed in a single central location. [13]

```
:root {
  --primary-color: #204CCF;
  --primary-color-contrast: #FFFFFF;
}

button.primary {
  background-color: var(--primary-color);
  color: var(--primary-color-contrast);
}

h1, h2, h3 {
  color: var(--primary-color);
}
```

Listing 4: Defining a primary color custom property that can be reused throughout the website.

The `@property` at-rule allows custom properties to be defined more precisely. It makes it possible to specify the expected value type using `syntax`, whether the property is inherited by default using `inherits`, and an initial value using `initial-value`. Possible syntax definitions include `<color>`, `<number>`, and `<url>`. Listing 5 shows how the previous `--primary-color` example can be expressed using this at-rule. [14], [15]

```
@property --primary-color {
  syntax: "<color>";
  inherits: false;
  initial-value: #204CCF;
}
```

Listing 5: Defining a primary color custom property using the `@property` at-rule.

As shown in Listing 6, custom properties can also be defined in JavaScript using `registerProperty()` or using `setProperty()`. [16], [17]

```
window.CSS.registerProperty({
  name: '--primary-color',
  syntax: '<color>',
  inherits: false,
  initialValue: '#204CCF ',
});

const root = document.documentElement;
root.style.setProperty('--primary-color-contrast', '#FFFFFF');
```

Listing 6: Using `registerProperty()` and `setProperty()` in JavaScript to define CSS custom properties.

Custom properties can also be read in JavaScript using `getPropertyValue()`, as shown in Listing 7. This makes it possible to react to dynamically changed values and use them in application logic.

```
const root = document.documentElement;
const contrastColor = getComputedStyle(root).getPropertyValue('--contrast-color');
```

Listing 7: Reading a CSS custom property in JavaScript using `getPropertyValue()`.

4.2.1. Global State Management

CSS custom properties are not limited to storing design values such as colors. They can also be used to manage application state. Because custom properties can be read and modified in both CSS and JavaScript, they provide a convenient way to store configuration values that directly influence the user interface.

For example, a user may not have enabled reduced motion at the operating system or browser level, but may choose to disable animations through a website-specific

setting. This preference can be stored in a custom property such as

`--prefers-reduced-motion: true`. The `@container` at-rule can then react to this value and apply different styles at runtime, as shown in Listing 8. [18]

```
:root {
  --prefers-reduced-motion: false;
}

@container style(--prefers-reduced-motion: true) {
  .animated-content {
    animation: none !important;
  }
}
```

Listing 8: Using the CSS `@container` at-rule to disable animations based on a custom property.

Another approach is to use a CSS attribute selector to override custom properties when a different color theme is selected. For example, the operating system and browser may indicate a preference for a light theme, while the user explicitly selects a dark theme on the website. In this case, a custom property such as

`--prefers-dark-theme: true` can be used to switch the application’s color palette, as demonstrated in Listing 9. [19]

```
:root {
  --prefers-dark-theme: false;

  --text-color:      #222222;
  --bg-color:        #FCFCFC;
  --border-color:    #EEEEEE;
  --primary-accent:  #0056B3;
}

:root[style*="--prefers-dark-theme: true"] {
  --text-color:      #EDED;
  --bg-color:        #212121;
  --border-color:    #232323;
  --primary-accent:  #6DB3F4;
}
```

Listing 9: Using a CSS attribute selector to switch to a dark color theme based on a custom property.

4.2.2. Custom Property Toggle

In modern CSS, developers often face the challenge of managing repetitive declarations, especially when implementing light and dark themes. Whether the switch is handled through classes or through

`@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark)`, the same property names typically need to be declared multiple times with different values. A lesser-known detail in the CSS specification makes it possible to implement this kind of state management more elegantly by using custom properties as toggle values.

According to the CSS specification, a custom property must contain at least one token to be considered valid. A single whitespace character satisfies this requirement and can therefore be used to simulate boolean-like values, as shown in Listing 10. [20]

```
:root {  
  --true: ;  
  --false: initial;  
}
```

Listing 10: Both `' '` and `initial` are valid values for custom properties.

In traditional theming setups, each variable must be defined separately for both the light and dark theme. By using the pseudo-boolean values introduced in Listing 10, the theme state can be stored in a single custom property, as demonstrated in Listing 11.

```
:root {  
  --is-light-theme: var(--true);  
}  
  
@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {  
  :root {  
    --is-light-theme: var(--false);  
  }  
}
```

Listing 11: Assigning either `' '` or `initial` depending on the active theme creates the basis for the toggle logic.

When `--is-light-theme` is used as a prefix in another custom property declaration, the resulting declaration is either valid or invalid depending on its value. If the prefix expands to a whitespace character, the declaration remains valid. If it expands to

`initial`, the declaration becomes invalid. In that case, the fallback value provided to `var()` is used automatically, as illustrated in Listing 12.

```
:root {
  --color-text--light: var(--is-light-theme) black;
  --color-text--dark: white;

  --color-background--light: var(--is-light-theme) white;
  --color-background--dark: black;

  --color-text: var(--color-text--light,
                    var(--color-text--dark));
  --color-background: var(--color-background--light,
                          var(--color-background--dark));
}
```

Listing 12: When a custom property becomes invalid, `var()` automatically uses the fallback value.

Multiple fallback values based on different toggle properties can be chained using the CSS `var()` function. This enables centralized state management, where the custom properties used throughout the entire style sheet are controlled from a single location. [21], [22]

An example of this theme toggle is available in the project's repository: https://github.com/Flaverus/P8_sandbox/tree/main/examples/theme-switch

4.3. CSS Functions

CSS provides a wide range of built-in functions that simplify common styling tasks. Some of these functions are particularly useful for accessibility. One notable example is `contrast-color()`, which became broadly available during the implementation of this project in April 2026 and is supported by current browser versions. The function returns either black or white, depending on which of the two provides the higher contrast against the color passed as its argument. Listing 13 shows this approach in the context of a `button` element. [23]

```
button {  
  background-color: var(--button-color);  
  color: contrast-color(var(--button-color));  
}
```

Listing 13: Setting the text color of a button to black or white based on the background color.

Using either black or white for text is a reliable way to ensure strong contrast. Depending on the background color, however, the result may appear visually harsh and less pleasant to read. Another recently introduced CSS function is `light-dark()`, which accepts two colors or images. The first value is used when a light color scheme is active, while the second value is used for a dark color scheme. Listing 14 demonstrates this approach using custom properties. [24]

```
body {  
  color: light-dark(var(--color-text--light),  
                   var(--color-text--dark));  
  background-color: light-dark(var(--color-background--light),  
                              var(--color-background--dark));  
}
```

Listing 14: Defining text and background colors based on the active color theme using custom properties.

4.3.1. CSS Custom Functions

Although the growing set of built-in CSS functions covers many use cases, some scenarios still require functionality that cannot be expressed with the currently available primitives. In such cases, developers may need to combine multiple functions or implement custom logic. This is where the experimental `@function` at-rule becomes relevant.

This feature is conceptually similar to CSS custom properties, as custom functions also use names that begin with `--`. A function is declared using the `@function` keyword, followed by a custom name and an optional list of parameters. Both the function name and its parameters start with `--` and are followed by case-sensitive identifiers defined by the developer. Inside the function body, the expression assigned to `result:` is evaluated and returned, as shown in Listing 15. [25]

```
@function --color-contrast(--color <color>) returns <color> {  
  result: oklch(from var(--color) calc((0.5 - 1) * infinity) 0 0);  
}
```

Listing 15: A custom function that provides behavior similar to `contrast-color()` and was created before that function became widely available.

As with CSS custom properties, CSS data types such as `<color>`, `<number>`, and `<string>` can be specified for both function parameters and the return value.

4.4. Color Spaces

There are many different models for describing the colors perceptible to the human eye. Each model has its own strengths and weaknesses and is used in different contexts, ranging from print and photography to digital displays.

For many years, CSS relied primarily on the RGB color space, which limited how colors could be described and manipulated. The CSS Color Module Level 4 specification introduced support for additional color spaces and more advanced color functions, significantly expanding the possibilities for working with color in CSS. Development in this area continues, and the W3C is currently working on the CSS Color Module Level 5 specification. [26]

4.4.1. RGB

The RGB color model represents colors by combining different intensities of the primary colors `red`, `green`, and `blue`. An optional alpha channel can be added to define the opacity of the resulting color.

RGB has been supported in CSS since its early days and can be expressed using the `rgb()` function or hexadecimal notation. For example, the color shown in Listing 16 can also be written as `#2d1fb180`. [26]

```
rgb(45 31 177 / 0.5);
```



Listing 16: Using `rgb()` to define a color from the Kolibri palette with 50% opacity.

4.4.2. HSL

CSS Color Module Level 3 introduced the HSL color model to CSS. HSL describes colors using three components: `hue`, `saturation`, and `lightness`, as illustrated in Listing 17. The hue is represented as an angle on the color wheel, while saturation and lightness define the intensity and brightness of the color. As with RGB, an optional alpha channel can be added to control opacity.

HSL makes it easier to create variations of a color because saturation and lightness can be adjusted directly without recalculating individual RGB values. This is particularly useful when generating lighter or darker shades of the same base color. [26]

```
hsl(256 82 55 / 0.6);
```



Listing 17: Using `hsl()` to define a color from the Kolibri palette with 60% opacity.

4.4.3. CIELAB Colors

Perceptual color spaces such as Oklab and OkLCH make it possible to define colors in a way that more closely matches human vision. They also provide access to a wider range of colors than those that can be represented in the traditional sRGB color space.

The `oklab()` function describes a color using three components: `lightness`, the `a` axis representing red-green variation, and the `b` axis representing yellow-blue variation. The related `oklch()` function uses `lightness`, `chroma`, and `hue` instead. Both functions support an optional alpha channel to control opacity.

These color models are widely regarded as the current state of the art for working with color in CSS because they produce more perceptually uniform results. In practice, this means that adjusting lightness or chroma leads to more predictable visual changes than with older color models. [26]

```
oklab(0.638 0.176 -0.279 / 0.7);  
oklch(0.718 0.255 301.5 / 0.7);
```

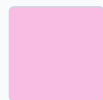


Listing 18: Using `oklab()` and `oklch()` to define a color from the Kolibri palette with 70% opacity.

4.4.4. HWB

The `hwb()` color function was introduced alongside the newer CSS color features. It describes colors using three components within the RGB color space: `hue`, `whiteness`, and `blackness`. In practice, it offers an alternative to `hsl()` that many developers find more intuitive when adjusting tints and shades. An example is shown in Listing 19. [26]

```
hwb(325 18 0 / 0.3);
```



Listing 19: Using `hwb()` to define a color from the Kolibri palette with 30% opacity.

4.5. Contrast Perception

Contrast is essential for distinguishing elements and understanding their relationships. Differences in brightness, size, texture, and shape all contribute to visual contrast. On the web, variations in lightness are the primary means of ensuring text readability and clearly separating interface elements.

The following section introduces the contrast requirements defined in WCAG 2.x and provides an overview of the emerging approach proposed for WCAG 3.0.

4.5.1. Relative Luminance

The contrast requirements in WCAG 2.x are based on the relative luminance of text and its background, independent of hue. This approach assumes that hue and saturation have little influence on reading performance, even for users with color vision deficiencies. Since the inability to distinguish certain colors does not usually affect the perception of light and dark, color itself is not treated as a primary factor in the contrast calculation.

In practice, the perceived contrast may differ from the theoretical value. Smaller or thinner fonts can appear noticeably lighter than the color specified in CSS due to anti-aliasing and font rendering. As a result, text may appear to have lower contrast than the calculated ratio suggests.

WCAG 2.x requires a minimum contrast ratio of 4.5:1 for normal text to meet Level AA. Large text must reach at least 3:1. For Level AAA, the minimum contrast ratio increases to 7:1. These thresholds are based in part on recommendations from ISO 9241-3 and are intended to compensate for reduced contrast sensitivity in users with moderate visual impairments. Users with more severe vision loss typically rely on assistive technologies such as screen magnifiers or screen readers.

Color vision deficiencies vary significantly, making it difficult to define universally effective color combinations based solely on hue. This is one of the main reasons why WCAG evaluates contrast primarily through relative luminance.

One notable exception is **protanopia**, in which red tones may appear significantly darker than expected. As a result, red text on dark backgrounds can provide much less contrast than the calculated ratio suggests and should generally be avoided. [27]

The formula shown in Listing 20 is used by WCAG 2.x to calculate relative luminance, which serves as the basis for determining contrast ratios. [28]

$$L = 0.2126 \cdot R + 0.7152 \cdot G + 0.0722 \cdot B$$

$$\text{Where } C = \begin{cases} \frac{C_{sRGB}}{12.92} & \text{if } C_{sRGB} \leq 0.03928 \\ \left(\frac{C_{sRGB} + 0.055}{1.055} \right)^{2.4} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Example: Dodger Blue `rgb(30, 144, 255)`

1. Normalize (/255)

$$R_{sRGB} = \frac{30}{255} = 0.1176$$

$$G_{sRGB} = \frac{144}{255} = 0.5647$$

$$B_{sRGB} = \frac{255}{255} = 1.0000$$

2. Linearize

$$R = 0.0123$$

$$G = 0.2747$$

$$B = 1.0000$$

3. Calculate Luminance (L)

$$L = (0.2126 \cdot 0.0123) + (0.7152 \cdot 0.2747) + (0.0722 \cdot 1.0000) = \mathbf{0.2712}$$

Calculate Contrast Ratio

$$\text{Ratio} = \frac{L1 + 0.05}{L2 + 0.05}$$

Listing 20: Step-by-step calculation of relative luminance based on the W3C sRGB formula. [28]

4.5.2. Perceptual Color Models

The contrast model used in WCAG 2.x is based on relative luminance. In the future, it is expected to be replaced by the Accessible Perceptual Contrast Algorithm (APCA), which forms part of the ongoing WCAG 3.0 work. Advances in display technology, modern web design, and vision science have shown that the approach introduced nearly two decades ago in WCAG 2.x no longer reflects how contrast is perceived in practice.

WCAG 2.x follows a binary model in which a contrast ratio either passes or fails. APCA takes a different approach by accounting for the non-linear nature of human perception and by evaluating contrast in the context in which the colors are used.

Readability depends on more than the luminance difference between two colors. Font size, font weight, stroke thickness, and surrounding context all influence how contrast is perceived. High light-dark contrast generally improves readability, but smaller and thinner text requires a greater difference in lightness to remain legible, as illustrated in Figure 1.

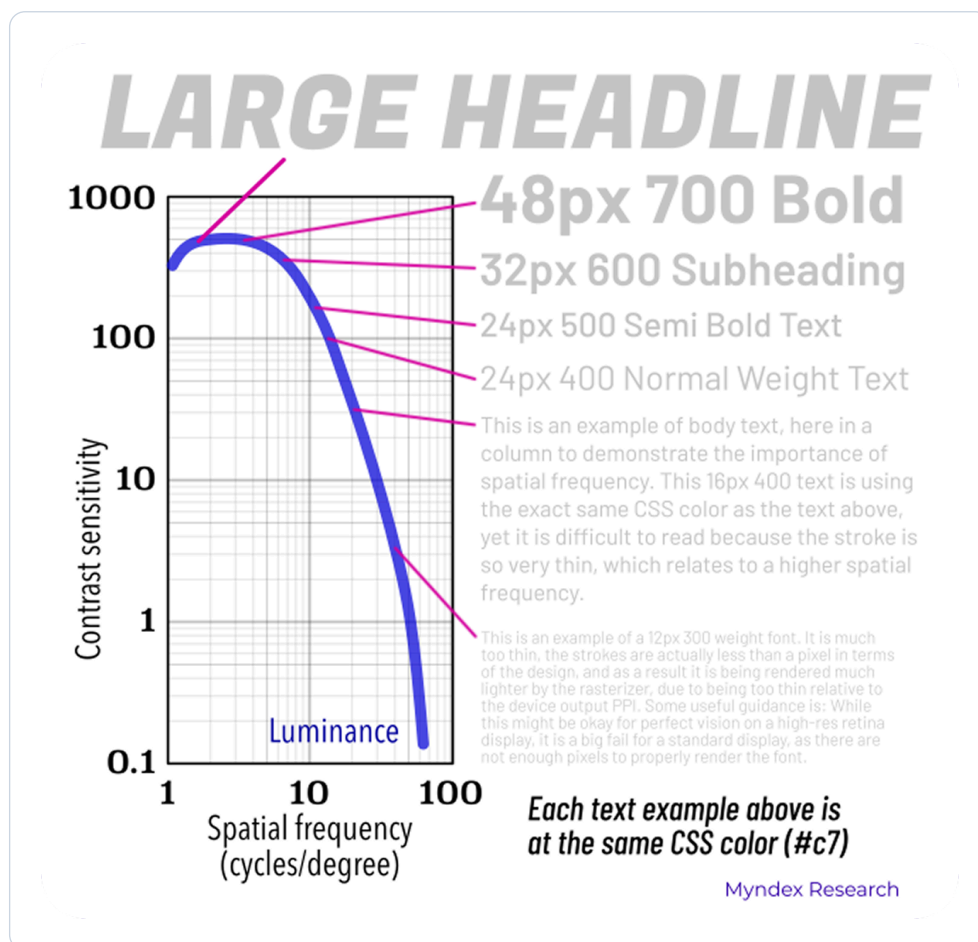


Figure 1: This chart illustrates the spatial dependence of human contrast sensitivity using text samples. [29]

Non-text elements such as icons typically require less contrast than body text. More generally, the appropriate contrast between two colors depends on the specific use case, including the size, thickness, and purpose of the element.

The contrast formula used in WCAG 2.x has been criticized for many years. Case studies comparing white and black text on colored backgrounds have shown that

combinations classified as inaccessible under WCAG 2.x were sometimes perceived as more readable by participants with color vision deficiencies. [30]

APCA introduces a new metric called lightness contrast, expressed as L^c . Instead of assigning a universal pass-or-fail threshold, it estimates readability based on the perceptual relationship between foreground and background colors within their actual visual context. [29]

4.6. Canvas

The HTML `<canvas>` element is used to draw graphics and animations directly within a web page. By default, the element has no visual representation of its own and must be rendered through JavaScript using either the `Canvas API` or the `WebGL API`.

The `Canvas API` is primarily designed for two-dimensional graphics and is commonly used for tasks such as game rendering, data visualization, image manipulation, and real-time video processing. The `WebGL API` extends these capabilities by providing hardware-accelerated rendering for both two-dimensional and three-dimensional graphics.

In addition to drawing content, the canvas also allows pixel data to be read and analyzed. The `ImageData` interface provides access to the underlying RGBA values of a rendered image. Listing 21 demonstrates how the color values of a selected area can be extracted in JavaScript. [31], [32], [33]

```
const canvas = document.createElement('canvas');
const ctx    = canvas.getContext('2d');

ctx.fillStyle = 'oklab(0.638 0.176 -0.279)';
ctx.fillRect(0, 0, 100, 100);

const red    = ctx.getImageData(10, 10, 10, 10).data[0];
const green  = ctx.getImageData(10, 10, 10, 10).data[1];
const blue   = ctx.getImageData(10, 10, 10, 10).data[2];
const alpha  = ctx.getImageData(10, 10, 10, 10).data[3];
```

Listing 21: Creating a purple 100×100 pixel square and extracting the RGBA values from a 10×10 pixel region starting at coordinates $x = 10$ and $y = 10$.

4.7. Ishihara

The Ishihara color test, named after the Japanese ophthalmologist Shinobu Ishihara, was developed in 1917 to detect red-green color vision deficiencies. The test consists of a series of circular plates composed of pseudo-isochromatic dots. These dots vary in size and color and are arranged in patterns that appear distinct to individuals with typical color vision, while blending together for people with certain forms of color blindness. [34]

An example of such a plate is shown in Figure 2. It uses orange and teal tones and is designed to remain visible regardless of the viewer’s color perception. Plates of this kind are commonly used as introductory demonstration images at the beginning of an Ishihara test.

4.7.1. Functional Application in Contrast Testing

Although originally developed as a diagnostic tool, the underlying principle of Ishihara plates also provides a useful framework for evaluating color contrast in interface design.

By placing many small dots of different colors next to each other, the method forces the visual system to rely primarily on chromatic contrast to identify a pattern. In a custom accessibility tool, if the foreground and background colors visually blend together within such a plate, this indicates that the chosen color combination may not provide sufficient perceptual contrast.

Custom plates can be generated using a specific brand palette to verify that key colors remain distinguishable not only for users with typical color vision, but also for users with conditions such as `protanopia` or `deuteranopia`.

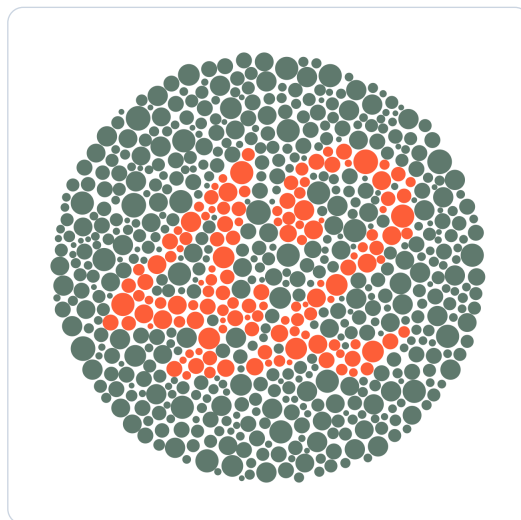


Figure 2: A high-contrast demonstration plate designed to remain legible across all common vision types.

5. Methodology

6. Implementation

This chapter presents practical approaches that extend existing browser standards to further improve accessibility. The **preferences widget** enables users to define website-specific settings tailored to their individual needs. The **contrast color function** expands the native `contrast-color()` CSS function by introducing an additional color component. The **interactive Ishihara plate** allows users to evaluate color combinations manually and to test contrast under simulated color vision deficiencies.

6.1. Preferences Widget

CSS media queries already make it possible to respond to certain user preferences. However, this only works when the user has configured the corresponding settings in the operating system or browser. If no such settings exist, websites have no reliable way to adapt to the user's individual accessibility needs.

Even when system-level preferences are configured, they may not reflect the requirements of every website. A user may prefer reduced motion in general, but still want to enable animations on a specific page, or the opposite. In addition, some accessibility preferences, such as color blindness simulations, are not currently covered by CSS media queries and therefore cannot be addressed through native browser mechanisms alone.

To overcome these limitations and give users greater control, the preferences widget shown in Figure 3 was developed. It uses existing system settings as a starting point, while allowing them to be adjusted and extended on a per-website basis.

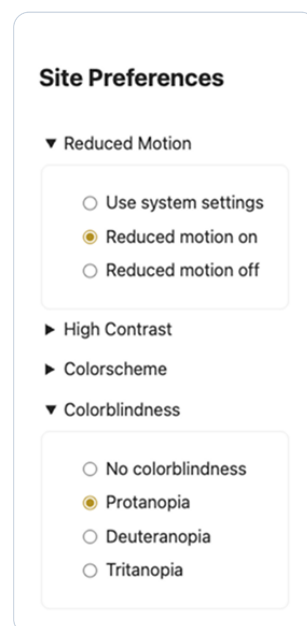


Figure 3: A screenshot of the preferences widget with page-specific settings for reduced motion and color blindness.

6.1.1. JavaScript Part

Where supported, existing CSS media queries serve as the foundation for the widget's default values. When a user visits the page for the first time, the current operating system or browser settings are used as the initial configuration. Any changes made through the widget are stored in the browser's `localStorage`, ensuring that preferences persist across page reloads and remain available throughout the application.

Each preference is also written to a CSS custom property on the `:root` element, making the value accessible from both JavaScript and CSS. This approach establishes a single source of truth that can be used consistently across the entire application, as shown in Listing 22.

```
const setAccessibilityProperty = (property,
                                value,
                                mediaQueryString) => {

  localStorage.setItem(property, value);

  if(value === 'system' && mediaQueryString !== '') {
    const systemSetting = window.matchMedia(mediaQueryString).matches;
    root.style.setProperty(property, systemSetting);
  } else {
    root.style.setProperty(property, value);
  }
}
```

Listing 22: The `setAccessibilityProperty()` function stores a value in `localStorage` and updates the corresponding custom property on `:root`.

The `getAccessibilityProperty()` function shown in Listing 23 reads a previously saved value from `localStorage`. If no value has been stored yet, it returns `'system'`, indicating that the operating system or browser setting should be used as the default.

```
const getAccessibilityProperty = (property) => {
  const savedProperty = localStorage.getItem(property);

  if(savedProperty) {
    return savedProperty;
  } else {
    return 'system';
  }
}
```

Listing 23: The `getAccessibilityProperty()` function returns a saved value or falls back to the system setting.

During page initialization, both functions are used to populate the custom properties with either the stored value or the corresponding system preference, as shown in Listing 24.

```
setAccessibilityProperty('--prefers-reduced-motion',
  getAccessibilityProperty(
    '--prefers-reduced-motion'),
  '(prefers-reduced-motion: reduce)');
setAccessibilityProperty('--prefers-contrast',
  getAccessibilityProperty(
    '--prefers-contrast'),
  '(prefers-contrast: more)');
setAccessibilityProperty('--prefers-dark-theme',
  getAccessibilityProperty(
    '--prefers-dark-theme'),
  '(prefers-color-scheme: dark)');
setAccessibilityProperty('--prefers-colorblind-mode',
  getAccessibilityProperty(
    '--prefers-colorblind-mode'),
  '');
```

Listing 24: Initializing the global custom properties with stored values or system defaults.

The `syncWidgetOption()` function shown in Listing 25 synchronizes the values stored in the custom properties with the corresponding radio buttons in the widget. By reading the values directly from `:root`, the custom properties remain the single source of truth for both the user interface and the underlying logic.

```
const syncWidgetOption = (option, property) => {
  const value = root.style.getPropertyValue(property);

  option.forEach((radio) => {
    radio.checked = radio.value === value;
  });
}

syncWidgetOption(motion, '--prefers-reduced-motion');
syncWidgetOption(contrast, '--prefers-contrast');
syncWidgetOption(colorscheme, '--prefers-dark-theme');
syncWidgetOption(colorblindness, '--prefers-colorblind-mode');
```

Listing 25: Synchronizing the selected radio buttons with the values stored in the custom properties.

Finally, each radio group registers a `change` event listener that updates both `localStorage` and the corresponding custom property whenever the user selects a different option, as shown in Listing 26.

```
addOptionEventListener(motion,
  '--prefers-reduced-motion',
  '(prefers-reduced-motion: reduce)');
addOptionEventListener(contrast,
  '--prefers-contrast',
  '(prefers-contrast: more)');
addOptionEventListener(colorscheme,
  '--prefers-dark-theme',
  '(prefers-color-scheme: dark)');
addOptionEventListener(colorblindness,
  '--prefers-colorblind-mode',
  '');

const addOptionEventListener = (option, property, mediaQueryString) => {
  option.forEach((radio) => {
    radio.addEventListener('change', () => {
      if (radio.checked) {
        setAccessibilityProperty(property, radio.value,
mediaQueryString);
      }
    });
  });
}
```

Listing 26: Updating the user's preference when the selected radio button changes.

6.1.2. CSS Part

Once the CSS custom properties representing the user's preferences are in place, they can be used to create different visual representations of the website. In Listing 27, a set of custom properties defines the default styling. These values are selectively overridden using the CSS attribute selector `[]` when the user prefers a dark color scheme.

```
:root {
  --bg-color:      #fcfcfc;
  --text-color:    #222222;
  --content-bg:    #ffffff;
  --border-color:  #eeeeee;
  --primary-accent: #0056b3;
  --shadow:        0 2px 8px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.1);

  color-scheme: light;
}

:root[style*="--prefers-dark-theme: true"] {
  --bg-color:      #212121;
  --text-color:    #EDEDED;
  --content-bg:    #2E2E2E;
  --border-color:  #232323;
  --primary-accent: #6DB3F4;
  --shadow:        0 2px 8px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.5);

  color-scheme: dark;
}
```

Listing 27: Overriding the default custom properties with the CSS attribute selector on `:root` to apply a dark color scheme.

As additional preferences are introduced, the number of possible combinations increases. Listing 28 demonstrates how the base styling is adjusted when both the dark theme and the high contrast mode are enabled, resulting in a different visual presentation.

```

:root[style*="--prefers-dark-theme: true"]
[style*="--prefers-contrast: true"] {
  --bg-color:      #000000;
  --text-color:    #ffffff;
  --content-bg:    #000000;
  --border-color:  #ffffff;
  --primary-accent: #80c5ff;
  --shadow:        none;
}

```

Listing 28: Applying a dedicated style when both dark mode and high contrast mode are enabled.

In some cases, changing individual custom property values is not sufficient and additional CSS rules must be applied. The `@container` at-rule combined with the `style()` query makes this possible. Because the preference properties are defined on `:root`, they can be used to conditionally apply styles across the entire application. Listing 29 demonstrates how animations and transitions can be disabled when the user prefers reduced motion.

```

@container style(--prefers-reduced-motion: true) {
  .animated-contents {
    animation: none !important;
  }

  .transitional-contents {
    transition: none !important;
  }
}

```

Listing 29: Applying additional styles based on custom properties using the `@container` rule and a `style()` query.

The implementation of the accessibility widget, including several example settings that demonstrate how individual and combined preferences affect the website's styling, is available in the project's repository: https://github.com/Flaverus/P8_sandbox/tree/main/examples/widget

6.2. Contrast Color Functions

The theory chapter introduced the native `contrast-color()` CSS function and demonstrated how similar behavior can be implemented using CSS custom functions. Given a color, `contrast-color()` returns either black or white, depending on which of the two provides the greater lightness contrast. While this approach is effective, pure black and white can appear visually harsh, especially when used for larger blocks of text.

To address this limitation, an enhanced version of `contrast-color()` was developed during this project and is shown in Listing 30. The custom function accepts a required parameter of type `<color>` and an optional `<percentage>` parameter named `--intensity`.

In the first step, the function determines whether black or white provides the better contrast by evaluating the lightness component of the input color in the OkLCH color space. If the lightness value is greater than or equal to 50%, black is selected. Otherwise, white is used.

In the second step, the selected contrast color is passed to the `color-mix()` function. The optional `--intensity` parameter controls how much of the original color is mixed back into the result. This produces a softer contrast color that retains some of the visual characteristics of the source color.

To further reduce extreme contrast, the lightness of the selected black or white is adjusted using the `clamp()` function. This ensures that light colors do not exceed a lightness of 97.5% and dark colors do not fall below 15%. As a result, the generated contrast color remains readable while appearing less visually aggressive.

```
@function --color-contrast(--color <color>, --intensity <percentage>:
0%) returns <color> {
  --black-or-white: oklch(from var(--color) calc((0.5 - 1) * infinity)
0 0);

  result: color-mix(in oklch, oklch(from var(--black-or-white)
clamp(0.15, 1, 0.975) c h), var(--color) var(--intensity));
}
```

Listing 30: A custom contrast function that softens pure black and white and optionally mixes in a portion of the original color.

The accompanying example from the project's example collection also calculates the WCAG 2.x contrast ratio for the generated colors, as shown in Figure 4.

Black or White as Contrast with Optional Color Saturation

Pick a color and get either black or white as contrast color, depending on the color's luminance. Additionally, a saturation percentage can be defined to move from a sharp contrast to a more pleasant one with color added.

Configuration

Background color

Saturation percentage

Results

Background: #be58fd

Foreground: oklch(0.200943 0.024045 354.977)

Contrast Ratio: 5.19:1

[Copy Resulting Color](#)

TEXT

Figure 4: A screenshot of the configuration interface for the custom contrast color function.

To calculate the WCAG 2.x contrast ratio, the RGB values of both colors are required. When colors are defined using functions such as `oklch()`, these values are not directly available, as browsers may preserve the original color format in the computed styles.

A practical workaround is to use the HTML `<canvas>` element. The canvas can be filled with any valid CSS color, and the resulting RGBA values can then be extracted using `getImageData()`. As shown in Listing 31, this technique makes it possible to convert any supported CSS color format into numeric RGBA values.

```
const parseColorToRGBA = (colorString) => {
  const canvas = document.createElement('canvas');
  const ctx    = canvas.getContext('2d');

  ctx.fillStyle = colorString;
  ctx.fillRect(0, 0, 1, 1);

  // Returning data array containing RGBA values as follows: r, g, b, a
  return ctx.getImageData(0, 0, 1, 1).data;
};
```

Listing 31: Extracting the `RGBA` values of any CSS color using the HTML `<canvas>` element.

The implementation of the custom contrast color function is available in the project's repository: https://github.com/Flaverus/P8_sandbox/tree/main/examples/contrast-color

6.3. Interactive Ishihara Plate

7. Discussion

8. Conclusions

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List of Aids

Artificial Intelligence and Language Models

Tool: Gemini (Google), Version 3 Flash.

Type of Usage: Used for linguistic refinement of drafts and formating mathematical formulas (Relative Luminance).

Extent: Specific paragraphs regarding WCAG luminance calculations were refined using the tool. All technical facts and code were manually verified for accuracy.